11

THE BJP'S RSS LINK

The Foundational Moment

'BJP Will Never Sever RSS Link'

Exactly two weeks after the BJP was founded in 1980, its first general secretary, L.K. Advani, addressed the first convention of its Gujarat unit with a clear message. The BJP, he bluntly asserted, 'would never sever its link with the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh'.[1] Nine months earlier, the Janata Party, which the Jan Sangh had merged with in 1977, along with other Opposition parties, had banned its members from having membership of 'any organisation having faith in a theocratic state'.[2] That political union—originally of five parties—broke up because many in the Janata Party questioned the 'dual' RSS membership of many ex-Jan Sangh members—a link they saw as synonymous with 'communalism'. This dispute proved to be the tipping point.[3]

After Indira Gandhi swept back to power in the 1980 election, Jagjivan Ram—the ousted Janata government's erstwhile deputy prime minister—announced on 28 February that he would 'not leave' the RSS 'dual membership issue' undecided and would 'pursue it to the end'.[4] This proved to be the final straw: the ex-Jan Sangh faction and several other leaders walked out of the Janata Party and created the Bharatiya Janata Party on 5 April 1980. They had with them fifteen of the Janata Party's twenty-eight Lok Sabha MPs, all fourteen of its Rajya Sabha MPs, five former cabinet ministers, eight